Are We Alone? A Short Guide to Space

Day 1 · Reading (1 of 2)

What to do: Read it aloud, one paragraph each. Stop at every blue word: can anybody explain it?

Vocabulary topic: Space and aliens
20 new words (in blue) · EEW 1, Unit 3 · read about space and talk about planets and aliens



easy parts harder parts (most new words are here)

Look at the sky tonight. What do you see? The Moon, some stars and maybe a **planet**. The brightest "star" in the evening sky is often not a star. It is Venus, our neighbor planet. You can see it with your own eyes, without a telescope.

The **universe** is very, very big. There are more stars in space than grains of sand on all the beaches of Earth. Our sun is only one of them, and our galaxy has about 200 billion stars. Do you ever feel small when you look at the night sky? Many people do.

How do we know all this? Scientists study space with big telescopes, and they put the information into **charts** and **reports**. A good report must **describe** what the scientists see, **solve** a problem and tell the reader why it is important. Sometimes the work is slow: a team can spend **several** years on one small question. One scientist cannot **comprehend** everything alone and can easily **fail**, so teams usually work together. The **view** from a telescope in space is much clearer than the **view** from the ground, because there are no **clouds**.

Space is cold, dark and silent. There is no air, so there is no sound. If you shout in space, nobody hears you. Astronauts talk to each other by radio.

Is there life **among** the stars? Many scientists **suppose** that the answer is yes. They think that in such a big universe, we cannot be alone. But nobody **ever** found an **alien**. Some people say we must look for simple life first, like small bacteria on Mars. Others say that an alien may not look like us at all. And if an alien is **friendly**, how can we talk to it? Scientists send messages with music and pictures, because numbers and music are the same everywhere.

Are We Alone? A Short Guide to Space

Day 1 · Reading (2 of 2)

What to do: After reading: which paragraphs were easy, which were hard? Which blue words did you know already?

In books and films, aliens are green, they have big heads and they come in round spaceships. In your book, Unit 3, a boy, Lee, meets a friendly alien who helps him with his school project. Read the story and compare it with the films you know.

Here is a good test for a student: **instead** of reading about a planet, build a model of it. Take a ball, some paint and a ruler. Make Mars red and Jupiter orange. Show the model to your class and describe it. You can get a good **grade** that way, and you learn more than from a long text. Go to the **library** first: the best books about space are there, with big pictures.

A small test for you: how long does light from the Sun need to reach Earth? About eight minutes. And light from the next nearest star? More than four years! When you look at the stars, you see the past.

There is also a problem with distance. The universe is so big that astronomers do not use kilometers. They use a light-year: the distance that light travels in one year, about nine trillion kilometers. The nearest star is four light-years away, and a spaceship needs thousands of years to get there. That is why many people **suppose** that we can meet aliens only through messages, not through travel. A good report must **describe** these numbers in a simple way, or nobody can **comprehend** them.

Do you like making models? Try this at home. You need a big ball for the Sun and a very small bead for the Earth. If the ball is one meter wide, the bead is only one centimeter, and it must be one hundred meters away. This is how big space is.

Some small facts to take home. A day on Venus is longer than a year on Venus. Jupiter has more than 90 moons. And the footprints on the Moon stay there for millions of years, because there is no wind. Tonight, **suddenly** remember that someone out there may be looking at our sun, too. Say hello!

The 20 words

Day 1 · Vocabulary table · Topic: Space and aliens

What to do: Book: 4000 EEW 1, Unit 3, pages 20–23. Copy the words you do not know into the copybook.

Word	Meaning	По-русски	Example
alien n.	a creature from another planet	инопланетянин	The alien came from another planet.
among prep.	in a group of things or people	среди	Lee sat among the books.
chart n.	a picture or table that shows information	диаграмма, таблица	The chart shows our grades.
cloud n.	a white or grey mass in the sky	облако	The spaceship flew through the clouds.
comprehend v.	understand	понимать	I couldn't comprehend the question.
describe v.	say what something is like	описывать	Describe your best friend.
ever adv.	at any time	когда-либо	It was the best day ever!
fail v.	not succeed	провалить, не суметь	He failed the test because he didn't study.
friendly adj.	kind and nice to other people	дружелюбный	Our new neighbor is very friendly.
grade n.	a mark in school	оценка	She got a good grade in math.
instead adv.	in the place of something else	вместо (этого)	I drank water instead of cola.
library n.	a place with books you can borrow	библиотека	We read books in the school library.
planet n.	a big round object that goes around a star	планета	Mars is the red planet.
report n.	a text that gives information	доклад, отчёт	Jack wrote a report about the stars.
several adj.	more than two, but not many	несколько	I read several books last month.
solve v.	find the answer to a problem	решать (задачу)	Can you solve this problem?
suddenly adv.	very quickly, without warning	вдруг, внезапно	Suddenly, the lights went out.
suppose v.	think that something is probably true	полагать, думать	I suppose you are tired.
universe n.	everything: space, stars and planets	вселенная	The universe is very, very big.
view v.	what you can see from a place	смотреть, рассматривать	We viewed the stars from the hill.

More on the topic

Day 1 · Topic: Space and aliens · more words

What to do: Choose 5 collocations to learn. Use the reserve words when a student already knows the main ones.

Collocations: words that go together

a school report	школьный доклад
solve a problem	решить проблему
describe a picture	описать картину
fail an exam	провалить экзамен
get a good grade	получить хорошую оценку
a friendly alien	дружелюбный инопланетянин
the view from…	вид из…
among friends	среди друзей
in the library	в библиотеке
several years	несколько лет
instead of…	вместо…
suppose so · I suppose	думаю, что да · полагаю

Phrasal verbs

look up	посмотреть (в словаре); поднять глаза	Look up the word in the dictionary.
take off	взлетать; снимать	The rocket took off at six.
set off	отправиться в путь	They set off early in the morning.
look forward to	ждать с нетерпением	I look forward to the trip.
find out	узнать	We found out the answer in the library.
hand in	сдать (работу)	Hand in your report on Monday.

Reserve words: for students who know the 20 already, or if you prefer another word

star	звезда	**orbit**	орбита
moon	луна	**gravity**	гравитация
rocket	ракета	**galaxy**	галактика
astronaut	астронавт	**sky**	небо
telescope	телескоп	**spaceship**	космический корабль

What to read next · 4000 Essential English Words

This week: **Book 1, Unit 3, “The Report”**, pages 20–25. Next: **Unit 4, “The Dog’s Bell”**, pages 26–31. Another story with a school problem: **Unit 2, “The Laboratory”**, pages 14–19.